

Translation vs. Localization

Why moving a text and moving an experience are two different jobs.

The short version

Translation transfers meaning from one language to another. Localization adapts the whole experience so that a product, page or document feels native to a specific market. Translation answers the question “what does this say?” Localization answers “does this work here?”

What translation does

Good translation preserves meaning, tone and register. It keeps terminology consistent, respects the author’s intent and reads naturally to a native speaker. For a contract, a research abstract or an article, accurate translation is often exactly what is needed.

What localization adds

Localization goes further. It adapts the elements that change between cultures and platforms, so the result does not merely read correctly — it behaves correctly:

- Dates, times, numbers, currencies and units of measure.
- Names, examples, idioms and culturally specific references.
- User-interface strings that must fit buttons, menus and limited space.
- Reading direction and layout for right-to-left scripts (Arabic, Hebrew).
- Search terms and on-page wording so the text still ranks (localized SEO).
- Tone and formality expected by the local audience.

A quick example

Element	Translation only	Localization
Date “03/04/2026”	Copied as-is	Reformatted per locale (Apr 3 vs 3 Apr)
“Save 50% today”	Literal wording	Persuasive wording + local currency
UI button “Submit”	Direct word	Fits length, tone and platform convention

When you need which

Choose translation for documents whose job is to be understood: contracts, academic texts, reports, correspondence. Choose localization for products whose job is to be used: websites, apps, landing pages, help centers and marketing experiences.

How Scriptorium handles it

Every project begins with scope: language pair, file type, audience and platform are confirmed first. Translation work is delivered with terminology control and human revision; localization work adds layout awareness, script-direction checks and a usability pass before delivery.

VERSIÓN EN ESPAÑOL

La versión breve

La traducción traslada el significado de un idioma a otro. La localización adapta toda la experiencia para que un producto, una página o un documento se sienta nativo en un mercado concreto. La traducción responde “¿qué dice esto?”; la localización responde “¿funciona aquí?”.

Qué hace la traducción

Una buena traducción conserva el significado, el tono y el registro, mantiene la terminología coherente y se lee con naturalidad. Para un contrato, un resumen académico o un artículo, suele ser justo lo que se necesita.

Qué añade la localización

La localización adapta lo que cambia entre culturas y plataformas: fechas, monedas y unidades; ejemplos y referencias culturales; cadenas de interfaz que deben caber en botones y menús; la dirección de lectura para escrituras de derecha a izquierda; y el SEO local. El resultado no solo se lee bien: funciona bien.

Cuándo elegir cada una

Elige traducción para documentos cuyo objetivo es comprenderse (contratos, textos académicos, informes). Elige localización para productos cuyo objetivo es usarse (sitios web, apps, landing pages, centros de ayuda y campañas).

The same idea across the six core languages

Language	“to localize”	“localization”
English	to localize	localization
Español	localizar	localización
Deutsch	lokalisieren	Lokalisierung
Français	localiser	localisation
Português	localizar	localização
Italiano	localizzare	localizzazione

Language Note published by Scriptorium for educational and editorial purposes. Examples are illustrative.

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